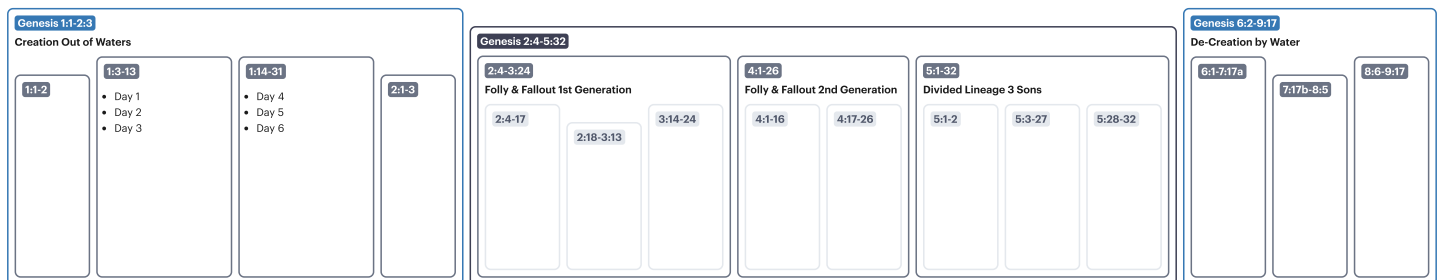


Session 2: The Thematic Melody of Genesis 1-9

Key Takeaways

- Chapter and verse numbers are not part of the original structure of the biblical text. Rather, literary units of the text are indicated by vocabulary and thematic shifts.
- Genesis 1-9 introduces a thematic melody moving from blessing to deception, curse, division, exile, violence, and de-creation before resolving in the rescue of a remnant to begin the cycle anew.
- The Yaaqov story is set to the thematic melody of Genesis 1-9, replaying through it many times.

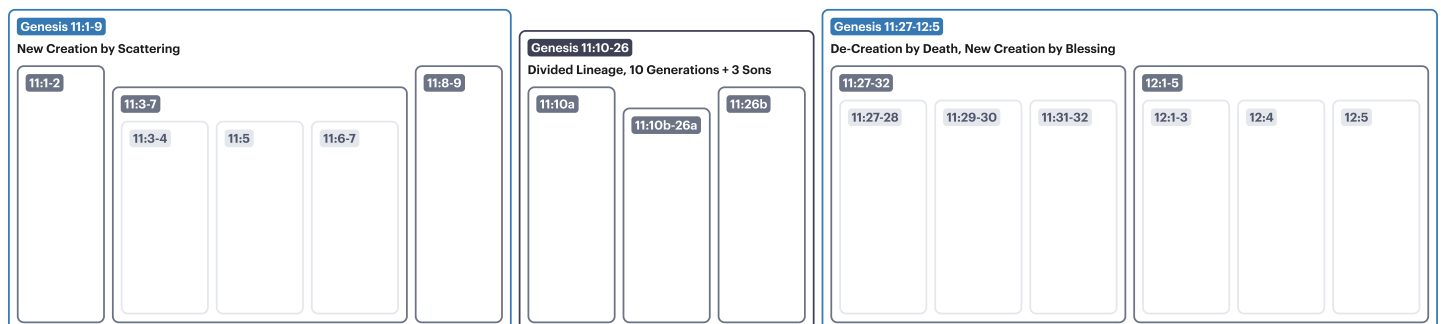
The Literary Design of Genesis 1-11



Genesis 1:1-9:17. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Abraham (2021).



Genesis 6:1-11:9. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Abraham (2021).



Genesis 11:1-12:5. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Abraham (2021).

These thematic cycles set up a thematic melody (a narrative pattern) that re-cycles with each generation, developing and advancing. The basic melody goes like this.

1. Creation and Blessing

- God bring order/life/blessing/ out of chaos/waters/death/curse
- Key words: life, blessing, create, establish, seed, sprout, grow, fruit, fruitful, and multiply; and seven, fullness, oath (all spelled שבע)
- Key images: dry land, refuge, safety, order

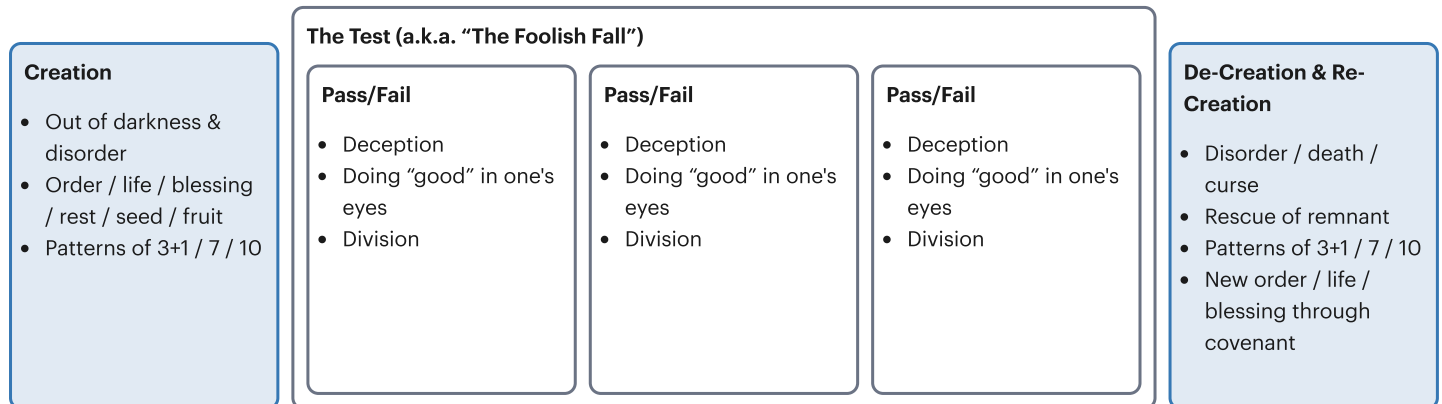
2. Folly, Test, and Failure (a.k.a. The Foolish Fall)

- God invites a chosen human partner to share in the order/life/bless, which places a decision/test of their trustworthiness on the table.
- God's chosen partner fails/succeeds the test, usually involving deception/division/violence.
- The same person/next generation faces their own opportunity and test, and fails/succeeds, usually involving an intensified expression of deception/division/violence.
- The escalating sequence of tests and failures leads to a separation between the key characters so that one person or family splits off from the rest and is chosen by God for a new future.
- Key words found in Genesis 2-3, 4-5, 6:1-4.

3. De-creation and Re-creation

- De-creation: God brings about an inversion of number one above, usually an escalation of chaos/death/curse.
- Out of that de-creation, God chooses/preserves a remnant/seed and begins a new movement of re-creation through them (often marked by covenants and wordplays on the Hebrew root שבע, "seven/fullness/oath" or "covenant," ברית).
- Key words found in Genesis 6:5-9:17

4. Repeat steps 1-3.

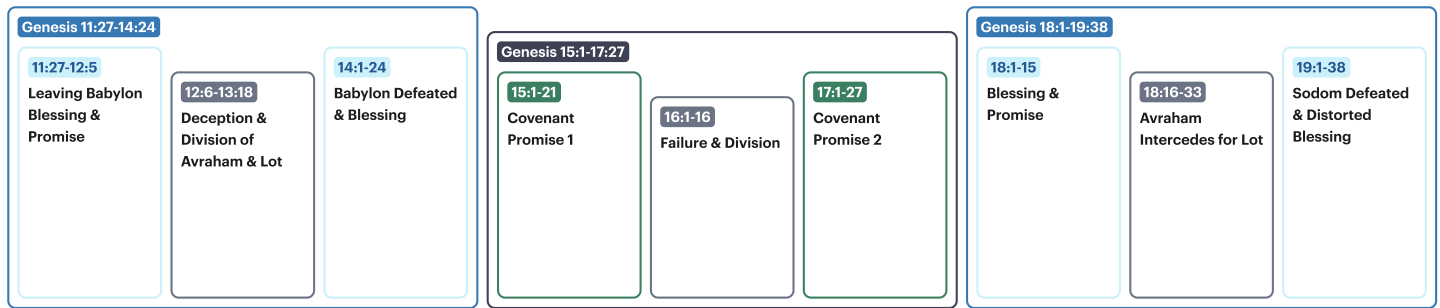


Genesis 1:1-11:26. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Abraham (2021).

The Abraham stories are organized according to this same thematic melody, as the cycle replays itself on the macro-level, medium-level, and micro-level of each part of the story.

The Literary Design of the Abraham Story

Part 1: Genesis 11:27-19:38



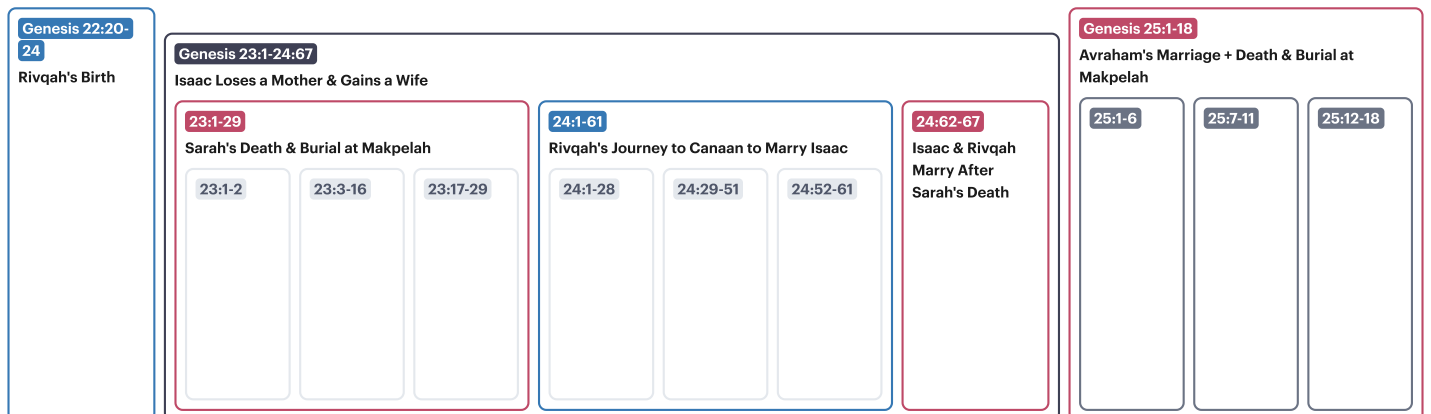
Genesis 11:27-19:38. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Jacob (2021).

Part 2: Genesis 20:1-22:19



Genesis 20:1-22:19. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Jacob (2021).

Part 3: Genesis 22:20-25:18



Genesis 22:20-25:18. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Jacob (2021).

Reflection Question

Are there any elements of the thematic melody of Genesis 1-9 you see connecting to the Yaaqov story already?